

NOVAMART GLOBAL RETAIL INC.

Customer Complaint Resolution Policy Manual

Standard Operating Procedures for Human Support Staff and the
AI Customer Complaint Resolution Agent

Document Classification: Internal Use Only

Version 3.0

Effective Date: July 6, 2026

Issued By: Office of the Senior Operations Manager, Global Customer Support

Table of Contents

1. Company Overview	3
2. Complaint Categories	5
3. Refund Policy	7
4. Replacement Policy	10
5. Return Policy	12
6. Shipping Policy	14
7. Billing Policy	16
8. Compensation Policy	18
9. Escalation Policy	20
10. Compliance Rules	22
11. Fraud Detection Rules	24
12. Customer Priority Tiers	26
13. Communication Guidelines	27
14. SLA Rules	29
15. Manager Approval Matrix	30
16. Exception Handling	32
17. Example Scenarios	34
18. Appendix	44

1. Company Overview

1.1 Purpose of This Manual

This Customer Complaint Resolution Policy Manual ("the Manual") establishes the official rules, decision criteria, and escalation pathways that govern how NovaMart Global Retail Inc. ("NovaMart", "the Company") resolves customer complaints across its Electronics, Fashion, Home Appliances, Furniture, Groceries, Beauty, and Accessories business lines. The Manual is the single source of truth for all Customer Support Representatives (CSRs), Team Leads, Duty Managers, and the AI Customer Complaint Resolution Agent ("the Agent") deployed to triage and resolve complaints across chat, email, voice, and marketplace channels.

The Agent must apply the policies contained herein exactly as written. Where a complaint does not clearly fall within an existing policy, the Agent must escalate to a Human Duty Manager rather than improvise a resolution. Deviation from this Manual without documented Manager approval is treated as a policy breach under Section 10 (Compliance Rules).

1.2 Customer Support Philosophy

NovaMart operates on the principle that every complaint is a signal of a broken promise, not an inconvenience to be minimized. Support exists to restore trust quickly, fairly, and consistently, regardless of the value of the order or the channel through which the customer complains. The Company's philosophy rests on four pillars:

- Fairness before speed: a resolution must be correct under policy before it is fast.
- Consistency across channels: a customer contacting NovaMart by chat, phone, or email must receive the same outcome for the same facts.
- Transparency: customers are told what will happen, when it will happen, and why a decision was made.
- Continuous learning: recurring complaint patterns are fed back to Category, Logistics, and Payments teams to reduce future complaint volume.

1.3 Customer-First Principles

The following principles must guide every interaction handled by the Agent or a human agent:

Principle	Operational Meaning
Assume good faith	Treat first-time complaints as genuine unless fraud indicators from Section 11 are present.
Resolve at first contact	Attempt to fully resolve the complaint in the first interaction wherever policy allows, without unnecessary transfers.
No customer left worse off	A customer who complains through a legitimate channel must never end up financially or materially worse off than before contacting support, provided the complaint is valid.
Right-size the remedy	The remedy must match the severity and category of the complaint; over-compensation is a compliance issue, not a courtesy.
Document everything	Every decision, approval, and customer communication must be logged in the Case Management System (CMS) with a policy citation.

1.4 Support Objectives

The Customer Support organization, including the Agent, is measured against the following annual objectives:

Objective	Target
First Response Time (all channels)	Under 15 minutes for chat/Agent-handled cases; under 4 hours for email
First Contact Resolution Rate	≥ 80% of eligible complaints resolved without escalation
Customer Satisfaction (CSAT) post-resolution	≥ 4.4 / 5.0 average
Policy Compliance Rate (audit sample)	≥ 99% of resolutions correctly applying this Manual
Escalation Accuracy	≥ 95% of escalated cases genuinely requiring human/manager judgment
Fraud Leakage	< 0.3% of total refund/replacement value paid out on confirmed fraudulent claims

1.5 Scope and Applicability

This Manual applies to all consumer-facing complaints relating to orders placed on NovaMart's website, mobile application, and authorized marketplace storefronts, across all seven product verticals: Electronics, Fashion, Home Appliances, Furniture, Groceries, Beauty Products, and Accessories. It applies uniformly across all countries of operation, subject to local consumer-protection law overriding any conflicting clause herein (see Section 10.7). B2B and bulk wholesale orders are governed by a separate Enterprise Servicing Agreement and are out of scope except where Section 12.6 (Enterprise Customer Priority) applies to support-tier handling.

1.6 Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
AI Customer Complaint Resolution Agent	First-line triage, categorization, policy-based resolution up to its approval authority, and structured escalation when thresholds are exceeded.
Customer Support Representative (CSR / L1)	Handles Agent-escalated cases requiring human judgment within Level 1 approval limits.
Team Lead / Supervisor (L2)	Approves mid-value refunds, replacements, and goodwill gestures within Level 2 limits; reviews Agent escalation quality.
Duty / Operations Manager (L3)	Approves high-value resolutions, exceptions, and fraud holds; owns Section 9 escalations.
Trust & Safety Team	Owns fraud investigation under Section 11 and account-level actions.
Legal & Compliance Team	Owns Section 10 sensitive complaints, consumer court, chargeback, and legal notice responses.
Regional Operations Director (L4)	Final internal authority for executive escalations and reputational-risk cases.

2. Complaint Categories

Every inbound contact must be classified into exactly one primary category before a resolution path is selected. If a complaint spans multiple categories (e.g., a damaged product that also arrived late), the Agent must log a primary category (the one driving the customer's core dissatisfaction) and up to two secondary categories, and apply the remedy rules of the primary category first.

2.1 Category Definitions and Initial Handling

2.1.1 Late Delivery

A complaint that an order has not arrived by the promised delivery date shown at checkout or in the shipping confirmation. The Agent must check live courier tracking before responding. If the order is still in transit and within 48 hours of the original promise date, the Agent offers a revised delivery estimate and a proactive shipping-fee waiver per Section 8.4. If the delay exceeds 48 hours past promise date, the complaint escalates to Section 6.2 (Delayed Shipment) for compensation.

2.1.2 Damaged Product

A complaint that the product received is physically broken, defective on arrival, spoiled (for groceries), or otherwise not in sellable condition. Photographic or video evidence is required for all categories except groceries with a shelf life under 7 days, where a verbal description is sufficient given spoilage risk. Damaged product complaints default to Replacement First per Section 4.1 unless the product is out of stock, in which case Full Refund applies.

2.1.3 Wrong Product

The customer received an item different from what was ordered (wrong SKU, size, color, or an entirely different product). The Agent must verify the discrepancy against the original order record. Wrong Product complaints are always eligible for either full refund or free replacement at the customer's choice, with return shipping paid by NovaMart, and do not require the customer to justify the request further.

2.1.4 Missing Product

One or more items from a multi-item order were not received, or a single-item order arrived with an empty or tampered package. The Agent must check the parcel weight recorded at the courier handoff against the expected weight. Where weight discrepancy corroborates the claim, or the order history shows no prior missing-item claims, the Agent may approve replacement or refund of the missing item(s) directly. Repeated missing-item claims from the same account trigger Section 11.1 (Repeated Refund Requests) review.

2.1.5 Refund Request

A direct customer request for money back, whether tied to a return, cancellation, non-delivery, or dissatisfaction. All refund requests are governed by Section 3 in full.

2.1.6 Replacement Request

A direct customer request for a like-for-like or equivalent replacement item rather than a refund. Governed by Section 4.

2.1.7 Billing Dispute

The customer disputes the amount charged, believes they were double-billed, charged after cancellation, or charged an incorrect price. Governed by Section 7. Billing disputes must never be closed without a reconciled transaction log reference number.

2.1.8 Payment Failure

Money was debited from the customer's account, wallet, or card but the order was not confirmed, or the payment failed but the customer was still charged. These are time-sensitive: the Agent must initiate an automatic reversal check with the Payments Gateway API within the same interaction.

2.1.9 Warranty Claim

A complaint raised after the standard return window has closed, relating to a manufacturing defect on Electronics, Home Appliances, or Furniture covered by a manufacturer or NovaMart Extended Warranty. Warranty claims are routed to the Warranty Service Desk per Section 4.2 and are not treated as standard returns.

2.1.10 Fraud Complaint

Either (a) a customer reporting that their account, payment method, or identity was used fraudulently, or (b) an internal flag that a complaint itself shows fraud indicators. Both trigger Section 11 immediately and must never be resolved with a standard refund or replacement without Trust & Safety clearance.

2.2 Category-to-Default-Remedy Quick Reference

Category	Default First Remedy	Human Approval Needed?
Late Delivery	Revised ETA + shipping fee waiver	No, unless delay > 7 days
Damaged Product	Free Replacement	No, unless item out of stock (then Refund)
Wrong Product	Customer choice: Refund or Replacement	No
Missing Product	Replacement or partial refund of missing item(s)	No, unless repeat pattern
Refund Request	Per Section 3 eligibility	Depends on amount (Section 3.9)
Replacement Request	Per Section 4 eligibility	Depends on value (Section 4.1)
Billing Dispute	Reconciliation then correction/refund	Yes, Team Lead
Payment Failure	Automatic reversal / re-credit	No, if gateway confirms failure
Warranty Claim	Warranty Desk routing	Yes, Warranty Specialist
Fraud Complaint	Account hold + Trust & Safety review	Yes, mandatory

3. Refund Policy

This section governs every monetary refund issued by NovaMart, regardless of category, and takes precedence over any conflicting statement elsewhere in this Manual.

3.1 Refund Eligibility

A refund may be issued only when at least one of the following conditions is met and evidence has been captured in the CMS case file:

- The product is confirmed Damaged, Defective, Wrong, or Missing per Section 2.
- The order was cancelled before dispatch, or within the applicable cooling-off window after dispatch under Section 5.
- The order was not delivered within the SLA defined in Section 6 and the customer no longer wants the item.
- A payment failure or duplicate charge occurred per Section 7.
- The product was returned in compliance with Section 5 (Return Policy) and passed inspection per Section 5.4.
- A Warranty Claim under Section 4.2 has been assessed as non-repairable and non-replaceable due to stock exhaustion.

Refunds are not eligible where the complaint concerns a Non-Returnable Product listed in Section 5.2, where fraud indicators under Section 11 are unresolved, or where the return window has lapsed without an approved exception.

3.2 Types of Refund

3.2.1 Full Refund

The entire order value, including item price and any shipping fee originally charged, is returned to the customer. Full refunds apply to Wrong Product, Damaged Product where no replacement stock exists, non-delivery, and cancellations made before dispatch.

3.2.2 Partial Refund

A proportional refund covering only the affected item(s) in a multi-item order, or a reduced amount reflecting product usage, missing accessories, or minor cosmetic damage that the customer has chosen to keep rather than return. Partial refunds must be calculated using the itemized price at the time of order, never the current listed price.

3.2.3 Store Credit

A NovaMart Wallet credit issued in lieu of cash, typically used for change-of-mind returns outside the cash-refund window, promotional order cancellations, or where the customer opts for credit in exchange for a bonus (see Section 8.1). Store credit never expires unless explicitly stated in a promotional term, and does not attract processing fees.

3.3 Refund Timelines

Refund Method	Processing Time (NovaMart side)	Time to Reflect for Customer
Original Payment Method (Card)	1 business day	5–7 business days (bank dependent)
Original Payment Method (UPI/Net)	Same day	1–3 business days

Refund Method	Processing Time (NovaMart side)	Time to Reflect for Customer
Banking)		
NovaMart Wallet / Store Credit	Instant	Instant
Cash on Delivery orders (bank transfer)	2 business days	3–5 business days
Gift Card repayment	1 business day	Instant on redemption

3.4 Refund Methods

Refunds must default to the customer's original payment method. Exceptions are permitted only where: the original method no longer exists (e.g., expired card), the customer explicitly requests Store Credit, or the order was Cash on Delivery, in which case a bank transfer or Store Credit is offered as a customer choice.

3.5 Refund Exceptions

The following situations are treated as exceptions requiring special handling rather than the standard workflow:

- International orders: refund is issued in the original transaction currency; foreign exchange variance is absorbed by NovaMart, never deducted from the customer.
- Promotional / heavily discounted orders: refund amount is the actual amount paid, not the pre-discount MRP.
- Bundled offers (e.g., Buy-1-Get-1): if one item in a bundle is returned, the discount is recalculated and the refund reflects the adjusted price of the retained item(s).
- EMI-financed purchases: refund is routed back through the financing partner to close or reduce the EMI schedule; NovaMart does not refund EMI interest already accrued unless the fault lies with NovaMart (Section 7.3).
- Gift orders: refund value is credited to the original purchaser's payment method or Store Credit, never to the gift recipient, unless the purchaser authorizes otherwise in writing.

3.6 Refund Limits

The Agent may autonomously approve refunds up to the limits in the table below without human sign-off, provided no fraud indicator is present and documentation requirements are met.

Refund Value (single case)	Agent Autonomous Approval	Required Documentation
Up to \$50 / ₹4,000	Yes	Category confirmation only
\$50.01 – \$200 / ₹4,001 – ₹16,000	Yes, if photo/video evidence attached	Evidence + order verification
\$200.01 – \$500 / ₹16,001 – ₹40,000	No — Team Lead approval required	Evidence + inspection report (if returned)
\$500.01 – \$2,000 / ₹40,001 – ₹1,60,000	No — Duty Manager approval required	Full case file + manager sign-off
Above \$2,000 / ₹1,60,000	No — Regional Operations Director approval required	Full case file + Finance notification

3.7 Manager Approval Thresholds

Approval thresholds in Section 3.6 apply per single case, not cumulative per customer. However, the CMS automatically flags any customer account that crosses \$1,000 / ₹80,000 in cumulative refunds within a rolling 90-day window for a mandatory Trust & Safety review before the next refund is released, regardless of the individual case value.

3.8 Refund Denial Handling

Where a refund does not meet eligibility criteria, the Agent must clearly state the specific policy clause that disqualifies the request, offer any applicable alternative remedy (e.g., store credit, repair, or warranty routing), and provide the customer a documented path to escalate to a human Duty Manager if they disagree. A refund must never be denied without a specific, citable policy reason.

3.9 Interaction with Compensation

Refunds are distinct from goodwill compensation (Section 8). A customer may receive both a refund for the item and separate compensation for the inconvenience caused, but the combined value of refund plus compensation must never exceed 150% of the original order value without Regional Operations Director approval.

4. Replacement Policy

4.1 Replacement Eligibility

Replacement is the default remedy for Damaged Product, Wrong Product, and Missing Product complaints where the same or equivalent SKU is available in inventory. Replacement is also available at customer choice for standard returns within the window defined in Section 5.1. Replacement is not offered where the product is discontinued, where the customer's return fails inspection under Section 5.4, or where fraud indicators are present.

4.2 Warranty-Based Replacement

For Electronics, Home Appliances, and Furniture, a defect arising after the standard return window but within the manufacturer or NovaMart Extended Warranty period is handled as a Warranty Claim. The product is first assessed by an authorized Service Center; if the assessment confirms a covered manufacturing defect and repair is not feasible within 10 business days, a replacement is issued. If no replacement stock exists, Section 4.4 applies.

4.3 Replacement Timelines

Product Category	Replacement Dispatch SLA	Replacement Delivery SLA
Electronics	1 business day	2–4 business days
Fashion & Accessories	1 business day	2–5 business days
Home Appliances	2 business days	3–7 business days
Furniture	3 business days	5–14 business days
Groceries	Same day (if within delivery cutoff)	Next-day
Beauty Products	1 business day	2–4 business days

4.4 Inventory Unavailable Scenarios

Where the exact SKU is unavailable for replacement, the Agent must offer, in order of priority:

- An equivalent or upgraded product at no additional cost, subject to Team Lead approval if the price difference exceeds \$30 / ₹2,500.
- A full refund, defaulting to the original payment method per Section 3.4.
- A backorder with an estimated restock date, only if the customer proactively agrees to wait and the estimated restock is within 15 days; otherwise a refund must be offered instead of an open-ended backorder.

4.5 Replacement Exceptions

- Groceries and perishable Beauty items past their use-by date are refunded, never replaced, once past the use-by date at the time of the complaint.
- Furniture requiring assembly: if the reported damage is assembly-related rather than manufacturing-related, a technician visit is scheduled before a replacement decision is made.
- Customized or personalized products (engraved, monogrammed, made-to-order) are replaced only where the defect is a NovaMart or manufacturing fault, never for change of mind.

4.6 Replacement Shipping Rules

NovaMart bears all shipping costs for replacements caused by Damaged, Wrong, or Missing Product complaints, including reverse pickup of the faulty item where applicable. Reverse pickup must be scheduled within 3 business days of the customer confirming replacement. If reverse pickup fails twice due to courier failure (not customer unavailability), the customer is not required to return the original item as a condition of keeping the replacement.

5. Return Policy

5.1 Return Windows

Category	Standard Return Window	Change-of-Mind Return Window
Electronics	10 days from delivery	7 days (unopened box only)
Fashion	15 days from delivery	15 days (tags attached)
Home Appliances	10 days from delivery	7 days (unopened box only)
Furniture	7 days from delivery	Not eligible (large-item logistics)
Groceries	24 hours from delivery (quality issues only)	Not eligible
Beauty Products	7 days from delivery (unopened/sealed only)	Not eligible (hygiene)
Accessories	15 days from delivery	15 days (unused, tags attached)

The return window begins at the timestamp recorded by the courier as "delivered," not the date the customer opens the package. Weekends and public holidays count toward the window unless local law requires otherwise.

5.2 Non-Returnable Products

The following are never eligible for change-of-mind return, and are eligible for defect-based return only where a genuine manufacturing fault is demonstrated:

- Opened or used Beauty and personal care products (hygiene policy).
- Innerwear, swimwear, and pierced-earring accessories once the hygiene seal is broken.
- Perishable groceries, fresh produce, and items with a shelf life under 7 days.
- Customized, monogrammed, or made-to-order Furniture and Accessories.
- Digital gift cards and downloadable software licenses once issued.
- Products explicitly marked "Final Sale" or "Clearance — No Return" at the time of purchase.

5.3 Condition Requirements

To qualify for return, a product must be in its original condition, defined as: unused (except where a defect is being demonstrated), with all original tags, seals, accessories, manuals, and packaging included, and free of any damage caused by the customer after delivery. Fashion and Accessories items must be free of odor, stains, or alterations. Electronics and Home Appliances must include all original chargers, remotes, and warranty cards.

5.4 Inspection Process

All returned items are routed to a Returns Quality Center before a refund or replacement is finalized, except where Section 3.6 permits a customer-evidence-only refund for low-value cases. The inspection process is:

- Step 1 — Intake scan: barcode/SKU match against the original order within 24 hours of warehouse receipt.
- Step 2 — Condition grading: Pass / Minor Wear / Damaged / Not-as-Described, recorded with photos.
- Step 3 — Outcome: "Pass" triggers automatic refund/replacement release within 1 business day; "Minor Wear" triggers a Team Lead review for partial refund per Section 3.2.2; "Damaged" or "Not-as-Described"

(i.e., customer sent back a different item) triggers a fraud-pattern check per Section 11 and the customer is notified with photo evidence before any adverse decision.

The customer must never be kept waiting beyond 3 business days from warehouse receipt for an inspection outcome. If the inspection SLA is breached, the case auto-escalates to a Team Lead and the customer is proactively notified with an apology and revised timeline.

6. Shipping Policy

6.1 Delivery SLA

Category	Standard Delivery SLA	Express Delivery SLA
Electronics	3–5 business days	1–2 business days
Fashion & Accessories	3–6 business days	1–2 business days
Home Appliances	4–7 business days	2–3 business days
Furniture	7–14 business days	Not available in all regions
Groceries	Same day / Next day	2–4 hour slot delivery
Beauty Products	2–5 business days	1–2 business days

6.2 Delayed Shipment

Where an order breaches its delivery SLA, the Agent must proactively act rather than wait for a complaint, per the escalating remedy schedule below:

Delay Beyond Promised Date	Automatic Remedy
1–2 days	Proactive notification + revised ETA
3–5 days	Notification + full shipping fee waiver/refund
6–10 days	Customer offered choice: continue to wait with a \$10/₹800 Store Credit goodwill gesture, or cancel for full refund
Beyond 10 days	Automatic full refund offered; order cancelled if customer does not respond within 48 hours, unless customer confirms continued wait in writing

6.3 Courier Delay (Third-Party Logistics Fault)

Where tracking data confirms the delay originates with the third-party courier partner (e.g., parcel static at a hub for over 48 hours), the same remedy schedule in Section 6.2 applies to the customer. Internally, the case is tagged "Courier-Fault" so that NovaMart Logistics can recover costs from the courier partner under the applicable service agreement; this internal recovery process must never be visible to or discussed with the customer.

6.4 Natural Disaster and Force Majeure Exceptions

Where a regional disruption (flood, earthquake, cyclone, wildfire, government-mandated lockdown, or similar declared emergency) affects a delivery route, the standard delay remedy schedule in Section 6.2 is suspended for the affected postal codes for the duration of the declared emergency plus 5 business days. The Agent must instead: acknowledge the situation with empathy, provide the best available revised ETA, and offer the customer a no-penalty cancellation for full refund at any time during the disruption. Force-majeure delays must never be used to deny a refund for an order the customer no longer wants; they only suspend the automatic escalating compensation schedule, not the customer's right to cancel.

6.5 Address Issues

- Incomplete or incorrect address entered by the customer: the Agent offers a one-time free address correction if the parcel has not yet left the origin facility; if already in transit, a redelivery fee may apply per courier terms, which the Agent must disclose before charging.
- Undeliverable address (courier cannot locate): the order is returned to the origin warehouse; the customer is offered redelivery with corrected address or a full refund minus original outbound shipping if the error was the customer's.
- NovaMart system error in address transcription: full remedy at NovaMart's cost, including express reshipment, with no charge to the customer under any circumstance.

6.6 Customer Unavailable Scenarios

Couriers must attempt delivery up to 3 times. If the customer is unavailable for all 3 attempts, the parcel is returned to the origin warehouse and the customer is notified. The Agent then offers: redelivery (customer bears redelivery fee only for the 4th attempt onward), pickup from a nearby NovaMart partner point where available, or cancellation with refund minus original shipping fee. Where the customer can demonstrate the courier did not genuinely attempt delivery (e.g., no call, no delivery photo, no missed-delivery slip), NovaMart bears the redelivery cost in full.

7. Billing Policy

7.1 Duplicate Payment

Where a customer is charged more than once for a single order due to a checkout retry, network timeout, or gateway error, the Agent must verify the duplicate charge against the Payments Gateway transaction log within the same interaction. Once confirmed, the duplicate charge is reversed automatically within 1 business day; no manager approval is required regardless of amount, since this is a confirmed system/gateway error rather than a discretionary decision.

7.2 Payment Gateway Failure

Where funds were debited but the order shows as "Failed" or does not exist in the Order Management System, the Agent must query the gateway reconciliation API. If the gateway confirms the debit, an automatic reversal is triggered; the customer is informed of the exact reversal timeline per Section 3.3. If the gateway shows no debit but the customer's bank statement shows one, the case is escalated to the Payments Operations team with the customer's bank reference number, and the customer is given a case ID and a commitment to update within 3 business days.

7.3 EMI Issues

- Incorrect EMI tenure or interest applied at checkout due to a NovaMart pricing display error: NovaMart absorbs the interest differential and coordinates directly with the financing partner to correct the schedule at no cost to the customer.
- Customer wants to cancel/return an EMI order: refund is processed to the financing partner to close the loan; any interest already accrued due to processing time is reimbursed by NovaMart only if the delay in processing the return exceeds NovaMart's own SLA in Section 5.4.
- EMI payment failure not related to NovaMart (customer's bank declines installment): this is outside NovaMart's remit; the Agent directs the customer to their financing partner and does not offer compensation.

7.4 GST / Tax Invoice Issues

Customers are entitled to a corrected tax invoice within 2 business days for any of the following: incorrect GSTIN/tax ID captured, incorrect billing name or address on the invoice, or incorrect tax rate applied. Invoice corrections do not require manager approval and must never be denied on the grounds of order age; tax record corrections have no return-window limitation.

7.5 Coupon Issues

Issue	Resolution
Valid coupon rejected at checkout due to system error	Order re-priced retroactively and difference refunded, or equivalent-value Store Credit issued
Coupon expired between cart addition and checkout (within 15 minutes)	Honored as a goodwill exception, one time per customer per quarter
Coupon terms misrepresented in marketing	Full coupon value honored; case flagged to Marketing Compliance

Issue	Resolution
Customer used ineligible/stacked coupons in error	Order re-priced to correct value; no penalty applied for a first-time occurrence

7.6 Wallet Issues

Where NovaMart Wallet balance is missing, incorrectly deducted, or a promised cashback did not post, the Agent must reconcile against the Wallet Ledger. Confirmed system errors are corrected immediately with no cap. Where a promotional cashback is delayed but not lost (still within its stated crediting window), the Agent provides the exact crediting date rather than an immediate credit.

7.7 Gift Card Issues

- Gift card not received after purchase: reissued immediately upon payment verification, at no cost.
- Gift card code invalid/already redeemed due to a system error: replacement code issued immediately after fraud check confirms the customer did not redeem it themselves.
- Lost/stolen gift card reported by the original purchaser: balance frozen immediately upon report; a new card is issued only after identity verification, since gift cards are bearer instruments and carry elevated fraud risk.

8. Compensation Policy

Compensation is distinct from a refund or replacement: it is offered to acknowledge inconvenience, time lost, or a degraded experience, over and above making the customer whole on the underlying transaction.

8.1 Coupons

Discount coupons (percentage or flat-value off a future order) are the default first-line compensation tool for low-severity inconvenience, such as a single-day delivery delay or a minor packaging issue with no product damage. Coupons must have a validity of at least 60 days and must not be restricted to a narrow, hard-to-use category.

8.2 Store Credit

Store Credit is used where the inconvenience is moderate, or where the customer has expressed a preference for credit over a coupon (e.g., because they do not plan to shop again soon). Store Credit compensation never expires and can be combined with other discounts, unlike promotional coupons.

8.3 Cash Compensation

Cash compensation (refunded to original payment method or paid via bank transfer) is reserved for cases involving a demonstrable financial loss to the customer beyond the order value itself — for example, a missed event due to a guaranteed delivery failure, or a documented medical/safety impact from a defective product. Cash compensation always requires Team Lead approval at minimum, regardless of amount.

8.4 Shipping Reimbursement

Any shipping fee the customer paid is refunded automatically whenever the root cause of the complaint is NovaMart's or the courier's fault (late delivery, damaged product, wrong product, missing product). Shipping reimbursement is never withheld pending a refund/replacement decision — it is processed immediately upon category confirmation.

8.5 Goodwill Compensation

Discretionary goodwill compensation may be offered even where the complaint does not strictly qualify for a remedy under Sections 3–7, in recognition of a poor overall experience (e.g., multiple contact attempts, long hold times, repeated miscommunication). Goodwill compensation is capped as follows and must always be logged with a specific reason code.

Approval Level	Maximum Goodwill Value (single case)
Agent (autonomous)	\$5 / ₹400 Store Credit
CSR / Team Lead	\$25 / ₹2,000
Duty Manager	\$100 / ₹8,000
Regional Operations Director	Above \$100 / ₹8,000

8.6 VIP Customer Compensation

Customers in the Platinum, VIP, or Enterprise priority tiers (Section 12) receive compensation at one tier above the standard goodwill matrix in Section 8.5 for the same severity of issue, reflecting their account value and relationship

history, but all compensation must still be logged and remains subject to the Maximum Compensation Limits in Section 8.7.

8.7 Maximum Compensation Limits

Across refund, compensation, and goodwill combined, the total value extended to a single customer for a single root-cause incident must never exceed 150% of the affected order value without Regional Operations Director sign-off, and must never exceed 300% of the affected order value under any circumstance short of a Legal & Compliance settlement (Section 10).

9. Escalation Policy

9.1 Escalation Levels Overview

Level	Owner	Typical Trigger
L0	AI Agent	Standard complaints within autonomous approval limits
L1	CSR / Human Agent	Agent confidence below threshold, or customer requests a human
L2	Supervisor / Team Lead	Refunds \$200–\$500, goodwill \$25–\$100, unresolved L1 case after 24 hours
L3	Duty / Operations Manager	Refunds \$500–\$2,000, fraud holds, repeated escalations, safety complaints
L4	Regional Operations Director	Refunds above \$2,000, legal/regulatory exposure, executive/media attention
Legal	Legal & Compliance Team	Consumer court notices, legal threats, chargebacks, police complaints

9.2 Supervisor Escalation (L2)

The Agent or L1 CSR must escalate to a Supervisor when: the resolution required exceeds L1/Agent approval authority, the customer explicitly asks to speak to a supervisor after a reasonable resolution attempt, or the same customer has contacted support 3 or more times about the same unresolved issue. Supervisor escalation must be acknowledged to the customer within 2 hours and actioned within 24 hours.

9.3 Manager Escalation (L3)

Escalation to a Duty Manager is mandatory for: any suspected fraud complaint, any complaint involving customer-reported injury or safety risk from a product, any case where the customer has referenced legal action or a consumer forum, and any refund/compensation decision within the L3 approval band in Sections 3.6 and 8.5. Manager escalation must be acknowledged within 1 hour for safety-related complaints and within 4 hours for all others.

9.4 Legal Escalation

Any complaint that references, or is accompanied by, a legal notice, a consumer court filing, a regulatory complaint (e.g., to a consumer protection authority), or a formal demand letter must be escalated to Legal & Compliance immediately and must not be independently resolved or settled by the Agent, CSR, Supervisor, or Duty Manager. The Agent's role is limited to acknowledging receipt and confirming that the matter has been routed to the appropriate internal team.

9.5 Fraud Escalation

Any complaint that trips a fraud indicator under Section 11 must be escalated to Trust & Safety before any refund, replacement, or compensation is issued. The account may be placed on a temporary review hold (order/refund restrictions only, not a full account ban) pending investigation, and the customer must be informed in neutral, non-accusatory language that the case requires additional review.

9.6 Executive Escalation (L4)

Executive escalation applies where a complaint carries material reputational risk: viral social media attention, press inquiry, a complaint from a public figure or regulator, or a request from a customer who identifies as a journalist or influencer in connection with the complaint. The Regional Operations Director must be looped in within 1 hour, and Corporate Communications is notified in parallel. The Agent must never attempt to resolve executive-tier complaints unilaterally, and must not offer any compensation beyond immediate acknowledgment while the escalation is in progress.

9.7 Escalation Communication Standards

Whenever a case is escalated, the customer must be told: that the case has been escalated, the expected timeframe for the next update, and a reference case ID. The Agent must never leave a customer with the impression that escalation means the complaint has been rejected.

10. Compliance Rules

Compliance Rules override every other section of this Manual. Where any conflict exists between a category-specific policy and this section, Section 10 governs.

10.1 Strict Refund Limits

No individual — Agent, CSR, Supervisor, or Duty Manager — may split a refund into multiple smaller transactions to stay under an approval threshold. Any refund identified as artificially split during audit is treated as a compliance violation regardless of intent, and both the original decision-maker and their approving manager are subject to review.

10.2 Approval Hierarchy

The approval hierarchy defined in Sections 3.6, 4, and 8.5 is mandatory and may not be bypassed by customer pressure, complaint volume, or time pressure. An Agent or CSR who feels a case genuinely warrants an exception to policy must document the justification and route it to the next approval level rather than granting the exception directly.

10.3 Sensitive Complaints

The following complaint types are classified Sensitive and require mandatory human handling from first contact — the Agent must not attempt autonomous resolution beyond acknowledgment and routing:

- Any complaint alleging physical injury, illness, or safety hazard caused by a NovaMart product.
- Any complaint involving a minor (a child's account, or a product marketed to/used by children) where safety or data privacy is implicated.
- Any complaint alleging discrimination, harassment, or abusive conduct by a NovaMart employee, delivery partner, or seller.
- Any complaint involving a customer's death or serious harm associated with an order (e.g., delivery of the wrong medication in a Pharmacy add-on order).
- Any complaint referencing self-harm or the customer's own wellbeing; these must be handled per NovaMart's separate Vulnerable Customer Protocol and routed to a trained human specialist immediately.

10.4 Consumer Court and Regulatory Complaints

Where a customer states they have filed, or intend to file, a complaint with a consumer protection forum, ombudsman, or regulator, the Agent must not argue the merits of the case or offer a settlement. The Agent acknowledges the complaint, confirms it is being escalated to Legal & Compliance under Section 9.4, and provides the customer a case reference number for correspondence.

10.5 Chargeback Handling

Where a customer has filed a chargeback with their card issuer, NovaMart's standard refund/replacement process is suspended for that transaction pending the chargeback outcome, to avoid double-remedy (refund plus chargeback reversal). The Agent informs the customer that the case is now handled through the chargeback dispute process and provides Payments Operations contact details for evidence submission if NovaMart intends to contest the chargeback.

10.6 Police Complaints

Where a customer reports that they have filed, or plan to file, a police complaint (e.g., regarding a stolen delivery, counterfeit product, or fraud), the Agent must treat this as a Fraud Escalation under Section 9.5 and a Sensitive Complaint under Section 10.3 simultaneously. The Agent should offer to provide any documentation (invoice, delivery proof, tracking history) the customer needs for their police report, without delay or conditions.

10.7 Legal Notice Handling

Any complaint accompanied by a formal legal notice, cease-and-desist, or advocate/attorney letter must be forwarded to Legal & Compliance within 1 hour without any substantive reply being sent to the customer by the Agent, CSR, or any support-tier employee. Only Legal & Compliance may respond to a legal notice on behalf of NovaMart.

10.8 Local Law Precedence

Where a local consumer-protection law grants the customer a right greater than what this Manual provides (for example, a longer statutory return window, mandatory cooling-off period, or a right to a specific remedy), the local law prevails and the Agent must apply it. Legal & Compliance maintains a jurisdiction-specific addendum referenced automatically by the Agent based on the customer's shipping country/state.

10.9 Social Media Escalation

Complaints originating from or amplified on public social media platforms must be escalated to the Social Media Response Team and Corporate Communications in parallel with standard case handling. The Agent must never negotiate a resolution via public comment threads; the customer is asked to move to a private channel (DM, email, or phone) for account-specific details, while a brief, empathetic public acknowledgment may be posted by the authorized Social Media team only.

11. Fraud Detection Rules

Fraud indicators do not, by themselves, prove wrongdoing. They require the case to be routed to Trust & Safety for review before any refund, replacement, or compensation is released. The Agent must never accuse a customer of fraud directly; language must remain neutral (e.g., "this case requires additional verification").

11.1 Repeated Refund Requests

An account requesting refunds or replacements on 3 or more orders within a rolling 60-day window, or claiming the same complaint category (e.g., "missing item") on 2 or more consecutive orders, is flagged for review. The current case is placed on hold pending Trust & Safety clearance rather than denied outright.

11.2 High-Value Abuse

A pattern of ordering high-value items and immediately filing a Damaged, Wrong, or Missing complaint, particularly where no independent evidence (weight discrepancy, courier scan anomaly) supports the claim, is flagged. High-value abuse review is mandatory for any single claim above \$500 / ₹40,000 combined with any prior flagged claim on the account.

11.3 Account Mismatch

Where the name on the payment method, the account holder name, and the delivery recipient name are all different with no prior gifting history or documented reason, the case is flagged for identity verification before a refund is released to a payment method that does not match the account.

11.4 Multiple Addresses

An account that has shipped high-value orders to 5 or more distinct addresses within 30 days, particularly across different cities or regions, is flagged for review, as this pattern is commonly associated with reshipping fraud.

11.5 Suspicious Payment Patterns

- Multiple failed payment attempts with different cards immediately followed by a successful high-value order.
- Use of a payment method previously associated with a confirmed chargeback or fraud case elsewhere in the system.
- An order placed and a refund/cancellation request submitted within minutes, repeated across multiple orders (potential card-testing behavior).

11.6 Identity Mismatch

Where a customer contacting support cannot verify basic account details (registered email/phone, last order details, or billing address) that a legitimate account holder would reasonably know, the Agent must not proceed with any refund, replacement, or account change until identity is verified through the standard two-factor verification flow.

11.7 Fraud Review Outcomes

Outcome	Action
Cleared — no fraud found	Case resumes standard resolution immediately; customer is not informed a fraud review occurred
Inconclusive	Duty Manager decides case-by-case, erring toward customer where evidence is genuinely ambiguous
Confirmed fraud — first instance	Refund/replacement denied; account restricted from future refunds pending manual review; no refund history impact if later reversed
Confirmed fraud — repeat	Account suspended; case referred to Legal & Compliance and, where applicable, law enforcement

12. Customer Priority Tiers

Priority tier affects response speed, escalation thresholds, and compensation generosity — it never affects whether a complaint is valid under Sections 2–7. A Normal-tier customer with a valid complaint receives the same fundamental remedy as a VIP customer; tiering changes speed and goodwill margin, not eligibility.

12.1 Tier Definitions

Tier	Qualification Criteria
Normal	Standard registered account, under 5 orders in the last 12 months
Silver	5+ orders or \$500+ / ₹40,000+ cumulative spend in the last 12 months
Gold	15+ orders or \$1,500+ / ₹1,20,000+ cumulative spend in the last 12 months
Platinum	30+ orders or \$4,000+ / ₹3,20,000+ cumulative spend, or active Premium Membership subscriber
VIP	Invitation-only tier for top 0.5% of customers by lifetime value, or flagged by Account Management for strategic relationship reasons
Enterprise	Registered business/bulk accounts under a separate Enterprise Servicing Agreement

12.2 Priority Handling Differences

Tier	First Response SLA	Dedicated Line	Goodwill Multiplier
Normal	Standard SLA (Section 14)	No	1x
Silver	Standard SLA	No	1x
Gold	25% faster than standard	No	1.25x
Platinum	50% faster than standard	Yes (priority queue)	1.5x
VIP	Immediate / dedicated agent	Yes (named contact where available)	2x
Enterprise	Per Enterprise Servicing Agreement	Yes (account manager)	Per contract

12.3–12.6 Tier-Specific Notes

Gold and Platinum tier customers are automatically routed past general queue triage to a Senior CSR for any case that the Agent escalates. VIP tier complaints must always be acknowledged by a human within 15 minutes, even outside standard business hours, via the on-call Duty Manager rota. Enterprise accounts are governed first by their specific servicing agreement; this Manual applies only where the agreement is silent on a given scenario.

13. Communication Guidelines

13.1 Professional Tone

All communication, whether generated by the Agent or a human, must be clear, respectful, and free of jargon, internal policy code names, or system error codes exposed to the customer. Sentences should be short and direct. The Agent must never sound scripted or robotic; responses should reference the specific facts of the customer's case rather than generic templates.

13.2 Empathy Standards

Every response addressing a complaint (as opposed to a general inquiry) must open by acknowledging the customer's specific experience before presenting the resolution. Empathy statements must be genuine and proportionate to the issue — a minor delay warrants a brief acknowledgment, while a damaged product or repeated failure warrants a fuller acknowledgment of frustration.

13.3 Apology Guidelines

- Apologize for the experience and the inconvenience caused, not in a way that constitutes a legal admission of fault where fault has not been determined (e.g., prefer "I'm sorry this happened" over "this was entirely our fault" when the cause is still under investigation).
- Never apologize on behalf of a third party (courier, seller) in a way that commits NovaMart to liability it may later need to recover from that partner — a sincere customer-facing apology is still required regardless of eventual fault attribution.
- Do not over-apologize repeatedly within a single message; one sincere, specific apology is more effective than several generic ones.

13.4 Forbidden Promises

The Agent and all human staff must never make the following commitments, as they exceed policy authority or cannot be guaranteed:

- Guaranteeing a specific delivery date/time for a replacement or redelivery beyond the SLA ranges in this Manual.
- Promising a refund or compensation amount that exceeds the employee's or Agent's approval authority without first securing the required approval.
- Promising that a specific employee, courier, or seller will be disciplined or terminated.
- Promising permanent account-level benefits (e.g., "you'll always get free shipping") without documented approval from Account Management.
- Committing NovaMart to a legal position, liability admission, or settlement figure — this authority belongs solely to Legal & Compliance.

13.5 Things Agents Must Never Say

Never Say	Say Instead
"That's not our policy, there's nothing I can do."	"Here's what our policy allows, and here's how I can help within that."

Never Say	Say Instead
"You should have read the terms before ordering."	"I understand this wasn't clear — let me walk you through what happened and your options."
"I don't know, I'm just an AI / just following the system."	"Let me check the details of your case and get you an accurate answer."
"This is the courier's fault, not ours."	"I'm sorry for the delay — here's what I can do to make this right."
"Calm down" / "You're overreacting."	"I can hear this has been frustrating, and I want to get this resolved for you."
Any statement admitting legal liability or guaranteeing litigation outcomes.	"I've escalated this to our specialist team, who will address it directly."

14. SLA Rules

14.1 First Response SLA

Channel	First Response SLA
AI Agent — Chat	Under 1 minute
AI Agent — Email	Under 30 minutes
Human CSR — Chat (post-escalation)	Under 5 minutes
Human CSR — Email	Under 4 hours
Human CSR — Phone	Under 2 minutes hold time
Social Media	Under 1 hour (public acknowledgment)

14.2 Resolution SLA

Complaint Complexity	Resolution SLA
Simple (Agent-resolvable, e.g., status inquiry, small refund)	Same interaction
Moderate (requires verification or Team Lead approval)	Within 24 hours
Complex (Duty Manager approval, inspection required)	Within 72 hours
Escalated / Legal / Fraud	Within 7 business days, with interim updates every 48 hours

14.3 Escalation SLA

Once a case is escalated, the receiving level must acknowledge receipt to the customer within the timeframes in Section 9, and must provide the customer a substantive update (not just an acknowledgment) at least once every 48 hours until resolved, even if the update is simply "still under review, here is the current status."

14.4 VIP SLA

VIP and Platinum tier complaints follow the accelerated SLAs in Section 12.2. In addition, any VIP case still unresolved after 24 hours automatically escalates to a Duty Manager regardless of case complexity, and any VIP case unresolved after 72 hours automatically notifies the Regional Operations Director.

15. Manager Approval Matrix

This section consolidates the approval requirements scattered across Sections 3, 4, and 8 into a single master reference table for quick lookup by the Agent and human staff.

15.1 Refund Approval Matrix

Refund Amount	Approval Required	Replacement Required First?	Documentation Required
Up to \$50 / ₹4,000	Agent (autonomous)	No	Category confirmation
\$50.01–\$200 / ₹4,001–₹16,000	Agent (autonomous, with evidence)	No	Photo/video evidence + order match
\$200.01–\$500 / ₹16,001–₹40,000	Team Lead	Only if replacement stock exists and customer prefers it	Evidence + inspection report
\$500.01–\$2,000 / ₹40,001–₹1,60,000	Duty Manager	Only if customer chooses replacement over refund	Full case file + sign-off
Above \$2,000 / ₹1,60,000	Regional Operations Director	No	Full case file + Finance notification

15.2 Replacement Approval Matrix

Replacement Value	Approval Required	Documentation Required
Up to \$100 / ₹8,000	Agent (autonomous)	Category confirmation
\$100.01–\$300 / ₹8,001–₹24,000	Agent (autonomous, with evidence)	Photo/video evidence
\$300.01–\$1,000 / ₹24,001–₹80,000	Team Lead	Evidence + stock confirmation
Above \$1,000 / ₹80,000	Duty Manager	Full case file + sign-off

15.3 Compensation / Goodwill Approval Matrix

Compensation Amount	Approval Required	Documentation Required
Up to \$5 / ₹400	Agent (autonomous)	Reason code only
\$5.01–\$25 / ₹401–₹2,000	CSR / Team Lead	Reason code + case summary
\$25.01–\$100 / ₹2,001–₹8,000	Duty Manager	Full justification
Above \$100 / ₹8,000	Regional Operations Director	Full justification + Finance sign-off

15.4 Special-Category Approval Overrides

Scenario	Approval Required Regardless of Amount
Any fraud-flagged case	Trust & Safety
Any safety/injury complaint	Duty Manager minimum; Legal if severe
Any legal notice or court filing	Legal & Compliance

Scenario	Approval Required Regardless of Amount
Any cash compensation (as opposed to credit/coupon)	Team Lead minimum
Any exception to a Non-Returnable Product rule	Duty Manager
Any case where prior approval was already given and is being revisited	Next approval level up from the original approver

16. Exception Handling

Exceptions in this section describe systemic, large-scale disruptions that affect many customers simultaneously. When Operations declares one of these exception states, the Agent must apply the modified rules below instead of standard policy, and must reference the specific declared exception code in the customer-facing message where appropriate.

16.1 Weather Delays

Where Operations has declared a Weather Delay Exception for specific postal codes, the standard Delayed Shipment schedule (Section 6.2) is replaced by the Force Majeure schedule in Section 6.4: no automatic compensation escalation, but unconditional free cancellation is available to the customer at any time, and proactive ETA updates must be sent at least once every 24 hours.

16.2 Courier Strikes

Where a declared courier strike affects a specific logistics partner or region, the Agent must offer to re-route eligible undispached orders to an alternate courier at no cost to the customer, or offer free cancellation. For orders already in the affected courier's network, the Force Majeure schedule (Section 6.4) applies, and the customer is not penalized for the courier's labor dispute.

16.3 Warehouse Fire or Facility Loss

Where a warehouse incident destroys or makes inaccessible inventory for pending orders, all affected orders are automatically cancelled with full refund processed within 24 hours, without requiring the customer to contact support. Where replacement stock exists at an alternate facility, the customer is offered the choice of automatic refund or a re-sourced shipment with a revised ETA, communicated proactively rather than waiting for the customer to notice the delay.

16.4 System Outage

Where a NovaMart system outage prevents normal order processing, payment confirmation, or the Agent's own case-handling systems from functioning, any customer-facing SLA in Section 14 is paused for the duration of the outage and resumes once systems are restored; customers must be informed via all available channels (status page, app banner, email) that a systemic issue is affecting service, and no customer should be penalized (e.g., treated as having missed a response deadline) due to an outage on NovaMart's side.

16.5 Product Recall

Where a product is subject to a manufacturer or regulatory recall, all affected customers are proactively contacted (the customer does not need to file a complaint) with clear instructions, and are offered, at their choice: full refund, free replacement with a non-recalled unit once available, or store credit with a bonus. Recall-related refunds have no value cap and do not count against the Section 8.7 maximum compensation limits, since this is a mandatory safety remedy rather than discretionary compensation. Any customer who reports illness or injury connected to a recalled product is immediately routed as a Sensitive Complaint under Section 10.3.

16.6 Natural Disasters (Broader Business Continuity)

Beyond the delivery-specific handling in Section 6.4, a declared natural disaster affecting a broader region (e.g., a customer's home city under a state of emergency) allows the Agent to apply extended flexibility across all policies:

return windows are paused (not forfeited) for the duration of the disaster declaration, payment-related deadlines are extended, and the Agent is authorized to waive standard documentation requirements (e.g., photo evidence) where the customer explains they cannot reasonably provide them under the circumstances.

16.7 International Shipping Exceptions

For cross-border orders, the following modifications apply to standard policy: customs delays are treated under the Section 6.3 Courier Delay framework rather than counted against NovaMart's delivery SLA once the parcel has left the origin country; customs duties or import taxes charged unexpectedly to the customer are reimbursed by NovaMart if the checkout page did not clearly disclose that duties were excluded; and returns of international orders extend the standard return window (Section 5.1) by an additional 10 days to account for cross-border transit time.

17. Example Scenarios

The following 30 scenarios illustrate correct application of this Manual across all product categories and complaint types. The Agent should use these as calibration examples when handling analogous real-world cases; they are illustrative, not exhaustive, and do not override the primary policy sections above.

Scenario 1: Late Electronics Delivery, Still In Transit

Complaint: A customer ordered a laptop with a promised delivery date of today; tracking shows it is still 2 days from the destination hub.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.1 (Late Delivery), Section 6.2 (Delayed Shipment)

Decision: Provide revised ETA and waive shipping fee proactively; no cash compensation yet since delay is under 48 hours past promise.

Reasoning: The delay has not yet exceeded the 48-hour threshold that triggers escalating compensation, so the standard proactive-notification remedy applies.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry your laptop hasn't arrived yet. Tracking shows it's currently 2 days out — I've waived your shipping fee and will send you a proactive update if anything changes.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 2: Damaged Blender Received

Complaint: Customer received a kitchen blender (Home Appliances) with a cracked jug and submitted photos.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.2 (Damaged Product), Section 4.1 (Replacement Eligibility)

Decision: Approve free replacement with reverse pickup of the damaged unit; shipping reimbursed automatically.

Reasoning: Damaged Product defaults to replacement where photo evidence is provided and stock exists; value is within Agent replacement authority.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry the blender arrived damaged. I've approved a free replacement, which will ship within 2 business days, and arranged pickup of the damaged unit at no cost to you.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 3: Wrong Size Dress Delivered

Complaint: Customer ordered a size M dress (Fashion) but received a size S.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.3 (Wrong Product)

Decision: Offer customer's choice of free replacement in correct size or full refund; NovaMart pays return shipping.

Reasoning: Wrong Product complaints are always eligible for refund or replacement at customer choice without further justification.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry for the mix-up — you should have received a size M. I can send the correct size right away at no charge, or issue a full refund, whichever you prefer.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 4: Missing Charger in Phone Order

Complaint: Customer's smartphone order arrived without the charging adapter that was listed as included.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.4 (Missing Product)

Decision: Ship the missing accessory at no cost within 1 business day.

Reasoning: First-time missing-item claim with no prior pattern on the account; approved directly by the Agent.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry the charger was missing from your order. I've arranged for it to be shipped separately, free of charge, arriving within 1 business day.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 5: Refund Request After Cancelling Sofa Order Pre-Dispatch

Complaint: Customer cancelled a furniture order (sofa) the day after placing it, before it was dispatched, and wants a full refund.

Applicable Policy: Section 3.1 (Refund Eligibility), Section 3.2.1 (Full Refund)

Decision: Approve full refund including any shipping fee charged at checkout.

Reasoning: Cancellation before dispatch is explicitly eligible for full refund under Section 3.1.

Correct Response to Customer: Your cancellation has gone through and a full refund, including shipping, has been initiated to your original payment method. It should reflect within 5–7 business days.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 6: Replacement Request for Faded Beauty Product Packaging

Complaint: Customer received a sealed skincare set with slightly faded outer packaging but the product itself is sealed and undamaged, and requests a replacement.

Applicable Policy: Section 4.1 (Replacement Eligibility), Section 4.5 (Replacement Exceptions)

Decision: Approve replacement of the item with intact packaging; no refund needed since product itself is not defective and customer wants replacement not refund.

Reasoning: Cosmetic packaging issue on a sealed, otherwise sellable Beauty item qualifies for replacement to ensure a fully satisfactory unit, within Agent authority.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry the packaging looked worn on arrival. I've arranged a replacement with fresh packaging, which will arrive within 2–4 business days.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 7: Billing Dispute — Charged Twice for Groceries Order

Complaint: Customer's bank statement shows two identical charges for a single grocery delivery.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.7 (Billing Dispute), Section 7.1 (Duplicate Payment)

Decision: Verify against gateway log; confirmed duplicate charge reversed within 1 business day.

Reasoning: Confirmed system/gateway duplicate charges are reversed automatically with no manager approval needed since this is a verified error, not a discretionary decision.

Correct Response to Customer: I've confirmed you were charged twice due to a checkout system error. The duplicate charge has been reversed and should reflect on your statement within 1–3 business days.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 8: Payment Failure on High-Value TV Purchase

Complaint: Customer says \$900 was debited for a television order, but the order shows as Failed in their account.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.8 (Payment Failure), Section 7.2 (Payment Gateway Failure)

Decision: Query gateway reconciliation API; gateway confirms debit; automatic reversal initiated.

Reasoning: A confirmed gateway-side debit with a failed order is a system error entitled to automatic reversal, regardless of the dollar amount, since it is not a discretionary refund decision.

Correct Response to Customer: I've confirmed the payment was deducted but the order didn't go through on our end. I've triggered an automatic reversal, which will reflect in your account within 5–7 business days, along with your reference number.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 9: Warranty Claim on 8-Month-Old Refrigerator Compressor

Complaint: Customer's refrigerator compressor failed 8 months after purchase, well outside the 10-day return window.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.9 (Warranty Claim), Section 4.2 (Warranty-Based Replacement)

Decision: Route to authorized Service Center for assessment; if confirmed manufacturing defect and unrepairable within 10 business days, issue replacement.

Reasoning: Compressor failure after the return window is a Warranty Claim, not a standard return, and must go through technical assessment before a replacement decision.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry about the compressor issue. Since this is outside our return window, I've booked a free assessment with our authorized service center; if it's confirmed as a manufacturing defect, we'll arrange a replacement.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Warranty Specialist

Scenario 10: Fraud Complaint — Account Used Without Authorization

Complaint: Customer reports an order was placed on their account for expensive electronics that they did not authorize.

Applicable Policy: Section 2.1.10 (Fraud Complaint), Section 9.5 (Fraud Escalation), Section 11.6 (Identity Mismatch)

Decision: Place order on hold, escalate to Trust & Safety, verify identity before any account or refund action.

Reasoning: Unauthorized account activity is a mandatory fraud escalation; no refund or account change may proceed without Trust & Safety clearance and identity verification.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry to hear this. I've placed the order on hold and escalated it to our Trust & Safety team, who will verify your identity and follow up within 24 hours with next steps.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Trust & Safety mandatory

Scenario 11: Delivery Delayed 8 Days for Furniture, Customer Wants Refund

Complaint: Customer's dining table order is now 8 days past its promised delivery date and the customer no longer wants to wait.

Applicable Policy: Section 6.2 (Delayed Shipment)

Decision: Offer immediate full refund per the 6–10 day delay tier, in addition to the option to continue waiting with a goodwill credit.

Reasoning: At 8 days delayed, policy requires offering both a wait-with-goodwill option and an immediate cancellation-refund option; customer has chosen refund.

Correct Response to Customer: I completely understand. I've processed a full refund for your dining table order, which will reflect within 5–7 business days, and I'm sorry for the extended delay.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 12: Courier Repeatedly Failed to Deliver Grocery Order

Complaint: A grocery delivery was marked 'delivery attempted' three times but the customer says no courier ever came or called.

Applicable Policy: Section 6.6 (Customer Unavailable Scenarios)

Decision: Full refund with no shipping deduction, since the customer can demonstrate the courier did not genuinely attempt delivery.

Reasoning: Where genuine delivery attempts cannot be evidenced (no call, photo, or slip), NovaMart bears the cost in full rather than treating it as customer unavailability.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry for this experience. Since there's no record of a genuine delivery attempt, I've issued a full refund with no deductions, effective immediately.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 13: Natural Disaster Delaying Beauty Product Shipment

Complaint: A flood in the customer's region has delayed their beauty order by 6 days; customer asks whether they'll get compensation.

Applicable Policy: Section 6.4 (Natural Disaster and Force Majeure Exceptions)

Decision: No automatic escalating compensation (force majeure suspends that schedule), but offer unconditional free cancellation and proactive ETA updates.

Reasoning: Declared regional disasters suspend the standard delay-compensation schedule but preserve the customer's unconditional right to cancel for a refund.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm so sorry for the disruption caused by the flooding in your area. Given the situation, I can't offer the usual delay credit, but you're welcome to cancel for a full refund at any time, and I'll keep you updated on the best available delivery estimate.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 14: Incorrect Address Entered by Customer, Package Already Shipped

Complaint: Customer realizes they entered an old address for an electronics order that has already left the warehouse.

Applicable Policy: Section 6.5 (Address Issues)

Decision: Attempt redirection with courier if possible; if not possible, treat as returned-to-origin with redelivery fee disclosed for customer error.

Reasoning: Since the error is the customer's and the parcel is already in transit, a redelivery fee may apply, but it must be clearly disclosed before charging.

Correct Response to Customer: Since the package has already shipped, I'll check if our courier partner can redirect it. If not, it will return to our warehouse and I can arrange redelivery — I'll let you know upfront if a small redelivery fee applies.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 15: Duplicate GST Invoice Error on Furniture Order

Complaint: Customer's tax invoice has the wrong company GSTIN, and they need it corrected for their own accounting.

Applicable Policy: Section 7.4 (GST / Tax Invoice Issues)

Decision: Issue corrected invoice within 2 business days; no return-window limitation applies.

Reasoning: Invoice corrections are never denied for order age and do not require manager approval.

Correct Response to Customer: I've corrected the GSTIN on your invoice. You'll receive the updated tax invoice by email within 2 business days.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 16: Coupon Rejected at Checkout Due to System Glitch

Complaint: Customer had a valid 20% off coupon that was rejected at checkout due to a technical glitch, and paid full price on an accessories order.

Applicable Policy: Section 7.5 (Coupon Issues)

Decision: Refund the coupon-equivalent difference to the original payment method.

Reasoning: A valid coupon rejected due to a system error is honored retroactively per policy.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry the coupon didn't apply properly. I've refunded the 20% discount amount directly to your original payment method.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 17: Wallet Cashback Not Credited

Complaint: Customer says a promised \$10 cashback from a promotional grocery order never appeared in their NovaMart Wallet.

Applicable Policy: Section 7.6 (Wallet Issues)

Decision: Reconcile against Wallet Ledger; if still within crediting window, provide exact crediting date; if past window, credit immediately.

Reasoning: Delayed-but-not-lost cashback within its stated window requires a specific date, not an immediate credit, whereas a missed window requires immediate correction.

Correct Response to Customer: I checked your wallet ledger — the cashback is scheduled to post by [date] under the promotion terms. If it doesn't appear by then, please reach back out and I'll credit it immediately.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 18: Lost Gift Card Reported by Purchaser

Complaint: Customer says the gift card they purchased for a friend was never delivered by email and the recipient never received a code.

Applicable Policy: Section 7.7 (Gift Card Issues)

Decision: Reissue the gift card at no cost after payment verification.

Reasoning: Gift cards not received after purchase are reissued immediately once payment is confirmed.

Correct Response to Customer: I've verified your purchase and reissued the gift card to the original email address you provided. It should arrive within a few minutes.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 19: Customer Requests Cash Compensation for Missed Birthday Event

Complaint: A birthday gift (electronics) guaranteed for next-day delivery arrived 4 days late, causing the customer to miss gifting it at the event.

Applicable Policy: Section 8.3 (Cash Compensation), Section 6.2 (Delayed Shipment)

Decision: Approve shipping refund and goodwill compensation; cash compensation considered given the demonstrable missed-event impact, subject to Team Lead approval.

Reasoning: A guaranteed-delivery failure causing a documented missed event qualifies for cash compensation, which always requires at least Team Lead approval.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm really sorry this affected your event — that's exactly the kind of promise we should have kept. I've refunded your shipping and escalated your case for compensation approval; you'll hear back within 24 hours.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Team Lead

Scenario 20: VIP Customer Reports Repeated Miscommunication

Complaint: A VIP-tier customer has contacted support three times about the same unresolved furniture delivery issue and is frustrated with inconsistent answers.

Applicable Policy: Section 9.2 (Supervisor Escalation), Section 12.2 (Priority Handling), Section 8.6 (VIP Compensation)

Decision: Escalate immediately to a named Duty Manager contact and apply VIP goodwill multiplier (2x) once the underlying issue is resolved.

Reasoning: Three contacts on the same unresolved issue mandates Supervisor/Manager escalation, and VIP tier requires immediate human acknowledgment plus elevated goodwill.

Correct Response to Customer: I sincerely apologize for the repeated back-and-forth — that's not the experience we want for you. I've escalated this directly to our Duty Manager, who will personally follow up within the hour.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Duty Manager

Scenario 21: Suspected High-Value Refund Abuse Pattern

Complaint: A customer claims their fourth high-value electronics order this quarter arrived damaged, with no corroborating weight or scan discrepancy.

Applicable Policy: Section 11.2 (High-Value Abuse), Section 9.5 (Fraud Escalation)

Decision: Hold the refund pending Trust & Safety review rather than approving or denying immediately.

Reasoning: A repeated high-value damage claim pattern without corroborating evidence meets the High-Value Abuse indicator and requires review before payout.

Correct Response to Customer: Thank you for reporting this. Your case requires a bit of additional review before we can finalize the outcome — our specialist team will follow up within 2 business days.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Trust & Safety mandatory

Scenario 22: Customer Threatens Consumer Court Filing Over Denied Refund

Complaint: A customer whose change-of-mind return was denied for a Final Sale item states they will file a consumer court complaint.

Applicable Policy: Section 10.4 (Consumer Court and Regulatory Complaints), Section 9.4 (Legal Escalation)

Decision: Do not argue the merits; acknowledge and escalate to Legal & Compliance with a case reference number.

Reasoning: Any stated intent to file with a consumer forum triggers mandatory Legal escalation and prohibits Agent-level settlement or argument.

Correct Response to Customer: I understand your frustration, and I want to make sure this gets the right attention. I've escalated your case to our Legal & Compliance team, and here is your case reference number for any further correspondence.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Legal & Compliance

Scenario 23: Chargeback Filed on Disputed Fashion Order

Complaint: Customer previously disputed a fashion order charge with their bank and has now also asked support for a refund on the same order.

Applicable Policy: Section 10.5 (Chargeback Handling)

Decision: Suspend standard refund processing on this transaction; direct the customer to the chargeback dispute process to avoid double remedy.

Reasoning: Once a chargeback is filed, standard refund processing must pause to prevent the customer receiving both a chargeback reversal and a NovaMart refund.

Correct Response to Customer: I can see a chargeback has already been filed on this transaction with your bank. Because of that, this specific charge is now handled through the chargeback process rather than a separate refund from us.

Manager Approval Required: No, but escalated per Section 10.5

Scenario 24: Customer Reports Minor Allergic Reaction to Beauty Product

Complaint: A customer says they developed a mild skin rash after using a purchased skincare product and wants it addressed.

Applicable Policy: Section 10.3 (Sensitive Complaints)

Decision: Route immediately to a trained human specialist; do not attempt autonomous resolution beyond acknowledgment.

Reasoning: Any complaint alleging a health or safety impact from a product is classified Sensitive and requires mandatory human handling from first contact.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm very sorry to hear this happened, and I want to make sure it's handled properly. I'm connecting you now with a specialist on our team who will follow up with you directly and urgently.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Duty Manager / Sensitive Complaint handling

Scenario 25: Product Recall on Electric Kettle

Complaint: A customer owns an electric kettle model that has just been issued a safety recall, and contacts support after seeing the notice online.

Applicable Policy: Section 16.5 (Product Recall)

Decision: Offer full refund, free replacement with a safe unit, or store credit with bonus — customer's choice; no value cap applies.

Reasoning: Recalls are a mandatory safety remedy, not discretionary compensation, so normal compensation caps do not apply.

Correct Response to Customer: Thank you for reaching out about the recall. For your safety, I can offer a full refund, a free replacement once the safe model is available, or store credit with a bonus — whichever you'd prefer.

Manager Approval Required: No, but logged per Section 16.5

Scenario 26: System Outage Delays Response to Refund Request

Complaint: A customer's refund request could not be processed for 6 hours because of a NovaMart-wide system outage, and they are asking why no one responded.

Applicable Policy: Section 16.4 (System Outage)

Decision: Acknowledge the outage transparently, confirm the SLA clock was paused, and process the refund immediately upon system restoration.

Reasoning: SLA timers are paused during a declared system outage and the customer should not be penalized or blamed for a NovaMart-side technical issue.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry for the delay — we had a temporary system outage that affected response times across the board. Your refund has now been processed and should reflect within the standard timeframe.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 27: International Order Delayed in Customs

Complaint: A customer's cross-border electronics order has been sitting in customs for 5 extra days beyond the delivery estimate.

Applicable Policy: Section 16.7 (International Shipping Exceptions), Section 6.3 (Courier Delay)

Decision: Treat the customs delay under the Courier Delay framework rather than counting it against NovaMart's own SLA; provide proactive updates.

Reasoning: Customs-related delays after the parcel has left the origin country are treated separately from NovaMart's controllable delivery SLA.

Correct Response to Customer: I understand the wait is frustrating — this delay is happening at customs rather than in our own network. I'll keep you updated regularly and you're welcome to cancel for a full refund at any point if you'd prefer not to wait.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 28: Unexpected Customs Duty Charged on International Beauty Order

Complaint: A customer was charged an unexpected customs duty on delivery for a beauty order, and the checkout page did not mention duties would apply.

Applicable Policy: Section 16.7 (International Shipping Exceptions)

Decision: Reimburse the customer for the unexpected duty in full.

Reasoning: Undisclosed customs duties at checkout are reimbursed by NovaMart, since the checkout experience failed to disclose the cost to the customer.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry this wasn't made clear at checkout. I've processed a full reimbursement for the customs duty you were charged.

Manager Approval Required: No

Scenario 29: Multiple Failed Payments Followed by Large Order

Complaint: A customer's account shows four failed card payments in ten minutes, followed by a successful \$1,200 electronics order, and the customer now disputes never placing it.

Applicable Policy: Section 11.5 (Suspicious Payment Patterns), Section 9.5 (Fraud Escalation)

Decision: Freeze the order and escalate to Trust & Safety before any refund or cancellation action.

Reasoning: Multiple failed attempts with different cards immediately followed by a high-value success is a classic card-testing/fraud signature requiring investigation before any customer-facing resolution.

Correct Response to Customer: Thank you for flagging this. I've placed the order on hold and escalated it to our Trust & Safety team for urgent review; you'll hear from them within 24 hours.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Trust & Safety mandatory

Scenario 30: Enterprise Account Bulk Order Delivery Discrepancy

Complaint: An Enterprise account ordering office furniture in bulk reports 3 of 50 units arrived damaged.

Applicable Policy: Section 12.6 (Enterprise Tier), Section 4 (Replacement Policy)

Decision: Route to the dedicated Enterprise Account Manager; apply the Enterprise Servicing Agreement terms for bulk replacement, defaulting to this Manual's Section 4 rules where the agreement is silent.

Reasoning: Enterprise accounts are governed first by their servicing agreement, with this Manual as the fallback, and always routed through a dedicated account manager rather than general queue.

Correct Response to Customer: Thank you for letting us know. I've routed this to your dedicated Enterprise Account Manager, who will arrange replacement of the 3 damaged units under your servicing agreement.

Manager Approval Required: Per Enterprise Servicing Agreement

Scenario 31: Social Media Complaint About Damaged Furniture Goes Viral

Complaint: A customer posts a video on social media of a damaged wardrobe with significant engagement, tagging NovaMart.

Applicable Policy: Section 9.6 (Executive Escalation), Section 10.9 (Social Media Escalation)

Decision: Escalate to Social Media Response Team and Regional Operations Director in parallel; move detailed handling to private channel.

Reasoning: Viral social attention triggers both social-media and executive escalation protocols; case specifics must move off the public thread.

Correct Response to Customer: We're sorry to see this, and we'd like to make it right. Could you please send us a direct message with your order number so our team can resolve this for you personally?

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Regional Operations Director + Social Media Team

Scenario 32: Customer Wants Refund on Opened Beauty Product Due to Change of Mind

Complaint: A customer opened and used a moisturizer, then decided they don't like the scent, and requests a refund.

Applicable Policy: Section 5.2 (Non-Returnable Products)

Decision: Deny change-of-mind refund on the opened beauty item; offer alternative product recommendation instead.

Reasoning: Opened Beauty products are explicitly non-returnable for change-of-mind reasons under the hygiene policy, with no discretionary exception available at Agent level.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry the scent wasn't what you expected. Since this product has been opened, it isn't eligible for a change-of-mind return under our hygiene policy, but I'd be glad to suggest a similar product you might prefer.

Manager Approval Required: No (denial does not require approval; any exception would need Duty Manager)

Scenario 33: Repeated Missing-Item Claims on Same Grocery Account

Complaint: A customer's account has filed a 'missing item' claim on 3 consecutive weekly grocery orders.

Applicable Policy: Section 11.1 (Repeated Refund Requests), Section 2.1.4 (Missing Product)

Decision: Hold the current claim for Trust & Safety review rather than auto-approving.

Reasoning: Two or more consecutive missing-item claims on the same account is an explicit fraud-review trigger regardless of the low individual value.

Correct Response to Customer: Thank you for letting us know. Because this is a recurring issue, I'm having our review team take a closer look to make sure everything is resolved properly; you'll hear back within 2 business days.

Manager Approval Required: Yes — Trust & Safety

Scenario 34: Warehouse Fire Cancels Pending Electronics Orders

Complaint: A customer's laptop order is cancelled without explanation after a warehouse fire; the customer contacts support confused and upset.

Applicable Policy: Section 16.3 (Warehouse Fire or Facility Loss)

Decision: Confirm automatic full refund already processed within 24 hours; offer re-sourced order at alternate facility if available.

Reasoning: Warehouse-loss cancellations are automatically refunded without requiring the customer to complain, and the Agent's role is to explain and offer alternatives.

Correct Response to Customer: I'm sorry for the confusion — a warehouse incident affected the inventory for your order, and it was automatically cancelled with a full refund already issued. If you'd like, I can also check if the same laptop is available for reorder from another facility.

Manager Approval Required: No

18. Appendix

18.1 Definitions

Term	Definition
Agent	The AI Customer Complaint Resolution Agent authorized to triage, categorize, and resolve complaints within defined approval limits.
CMS	Case Management System — the internal system of record for all complaint cases, decisions, and approvals.
CSR	Customer Support Representative — a human, first-line support employee (Level 1).
Duty Manager	The Level 3 human approver responsible for high-value and exception decisions during a given shift.
Force Majeure	An event beyond NovaMart's reasonable control (natural disaster, strike, government action) that suspends standard delay-compensation obligations.
Goodwill Compensation	Discretionary compensation offered to acknowledge a poor experience, separate from a refund or replacement.
Inspection	The Returns Quality Center's process of grading a returned item's condition before finalizing a refund or replacement.
SKU	Stock Keeping Unit — the unique identifier for a specific product variant (size, color, model).
SLA	Service Level Agreement — the maximum allowable time for a defined action (response, resolution, delivery).
Trust & Safety	The internal team responsible for fraud investigation and account-risk decisions.

18.2 Glossary of Complaint Categories

Category	Short Definition
Late Delivery	Order not received by the promised delivery date.
Damaged Product	Item received in physically broken or defective condition.
Wrong Product	Item received differs from what was ordered.
Missing Product	One or more ordered items were not received.
Refund Request	Direct request for monetary return of funds.
Replacement Request	Direct request for a like-for-like or equivalent item.
Billing Dispute	Disagreement over the amount or validity of a charge.
Payment Failure	Funds debited without a corresponding confirmed order.
Warranty Claim	Post-return-window defect claim under manufacturer or extended warranty.
Fraud Complaint	A report or indicator of unauthorized or fraudulent account/order activity.

18.3 Important Terms and Abbreviations

Term	Meaning
L0 / L1 / L2 / L3 / L4	Escalation levels: Agent, CSR, Supervisor, Duty Manager, Regional Operations Director respectively.
EMI	Equated Monthly Installment — a financed payment plan for an order.
GST / Tax ID	Goods and Services Tax identifier or equivalent regional tax registration number.
MRP	Maximum Retail Price — the pre-discount listed price of a product.
OMS	Order Management System — the internal system recording order lifecycle status.
CSAT	Customer Satisfaction Score, typically measured on a 5-point scale after case resolution.
Reverse Pickup	Courier collection of a returned or faulty item from the customer's address.
Chargeback	A payment reversal initiated by a customer's card issuer/bank rather than by NovaMart.
VIP	Very Important Person tier — top-tier customer priority classification.
KYC	Know Your Customer — identity verification process used in fraud and high-risk cases.

18.4 Document Control

Field	Value
Document Owner	Senior Operations Manager, Global Customer Support
Applies To	AI Customer Complaint Resolution Agent; all Customer Support, Trust & Safety, and Legal & Compliance staff
Review Cycle	Reviewed and reissued annually, or immediately upon material change to refund, compensation, or legal-compliance requirements
Classification	Internal Use Only — Not for External Distribution